

Satellites and space junk

The first satellite, *Sputnik 1*, was launched by the Soviet Union in 1957. Since then, thousands of satellites and millions of other objects have accumulated around Earth, creating a serious hazard for space travel.

Geosynchronous ring

This ring-shaped concentration of satellites appears more than 22,200 miles (35,700 km) above Earth's equator. It exists because it is extremely useful for a satellite to "hover" above a point on Earth's turning surface.

High-speed danger

The pattern of spots shows the strikes collected during the entire NASA Space Shuttle program, from 1983–2002. The vast majority of space debris is less than 0.5 in (1 cm) across and includes specks of solid rocket fuel and flakes of paint. But even dust acts like tiny bullets at speeds of up to 26,000 mph (42,000 kph).

